

- Medical expenses are the primary expenses
- Stressed out
- Hydration
- Influence of Health Conditions on Heat Intolerance
- Personal Responsibility for Transportation
- Fatigue
- Conditional support
- Cutting Back on Non-Essentials
- Balancing between extreme temperatures (heat vs. cold)
- Appropriate attire
- Decreased Heat Tolerance with Age and Weight Gain
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- Sensitivity to Sun
- Insurance with or without copay
- Heat Avoidance as a Priority

Coding Density

Interviewer: I'm gonna start by asking about your medical history.

Interviewer: So you mentioned that you are recovering from cancer. What type of cancer were you diagnosed with? And are there any other conditions that you're managing?

Participant: Prostate cancer.

Interviewer: Okay, prostate cancer. And do you have any other kind of condition?

Interviewer: Yeah, yeah. Well, I love that. Okay. I apologize for the interruption. So I was. I was asking, it does. In addition to, you know, being a cancer survivor, are there any other conditions that you're currently managing like high blood pressure or diabetes or

Interviewer: arthritis? I don't know.

Participant: I do have type 2 diabetes for a very long time, I'd say about 15 years or more, maybe 20.

Interviewer: Wow. Okay.

Participant: It was over 20. Yeah.

Interviewer: Wow, okay?

Interviewer: So, I'll ask, I'm gonna ask you 2 separate questions. So what medications are you currently on to manage your type 2 diabetes.

Participant: I'm on metformin. I'm on glipizide. Sometimes I take farxiga If I have any spike for the most part. I stopped taking that when they got me on Ozempic. But between the fact that my insurance wouldn't cover the cost of Ozempic, it has a very high Co pay. I just went back to the minutes, and it's not real change.

Interviewer: Okay, okay, I'm glad that you found something that we're excited is also covered. And

Interviewer: for your cancer, what type of treatment did you undergo.

Participant: I had surgery to remove the prostate. That didn't get all of it. So, I did the radiation that didn't get all of it. So, they put me on neutron for 2 years.

Interviewer: Oh, my goodness!

Participant: That! Oh. That ended last November. So now we're just looking for the loop ring to wear off to see if the prostate cancer is all gone, or if it's just lurking.

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Interviewer: Okay, okay.

Interviewer: interesting. That sounds very anxiety inducing

Participant: I mean, it's undetectable. But if it's undetectable and you hardly have testosterone, it's not really an indication. It's gone.

Interviewer: Very well informed about your health condition.

Participant: Yeah, I feel bad for the surging, because when he says, hey, look your results. And I'm like, Yeah, and I have no test talk to him so that proves nothing, and he's like, Oh.

Participant: I say, I'm just trying to be realistic, you know. I'm not ungrateful, but I'm just being realistic until my testosterone is back to full. If my PSA is undetectable at that point that tells me something

Participant: I don't like Paul, so. I like facts.

Interviewer: Like real things. Okay, I think you might enjoy this interview. Then we can talk about some real things. So.

Participant: I don't like that sugar coat, and I don't like just to believe something, and then I get a surprise. I like to be prepared. I knew the cancer was coming from family. So, I was biting, waiting for them to say, okay, it jumped. I said, yep. Finally.

Interviewer: Not finally, but it is good that you were prepared, you know, staying up to date with your screenings and things, staying vigilant.

Participant: Oh, yeah, I've been. I've been prepared for the last 25 years waiting for that day. My grandfather, my great grandfather, my father, my uncle. So, it was inevitable.

Interviewer: Wow!

Interviewer: Let me ask. So you, I know you have some medications for your diabetes that probably need to be refrigerated. Is that correct?

Participant: No, actually, all of it is just pills and room temperature.

Interviewer: Oh, okay, so you don't have any medications or or medical equipment that requires you to have access to electricity.

Participant: No, I mean, even the Ozempic didn't require the refrigeration. So yeah. Everything is just no insulin. Everything's just basically pills. And just watch your carbs.

Interviewer: Okay,

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Interviewer: Let me ask. So, since your diagnosis you seem like you were well prepared. But did you experience, or have you experienced any like stressful life events that impacted your ability to cope with that news like unexpected expenses or medical emergencies other than your diagnosis or a change in your employment that kind of thing.

Participant: Well, I did get some surprises, I guess, when I hit my copay so quickly on the 1st year of the surgery and radiation. And then, when the year cycle and the radiation continued, now with a huge Co pay that I didn't expect. And I said, what happened? They say, well, you know you have to meet your copay again. so, I had to pay.

Participant: Around. I forget if it was 3, 5, or \$8,000 that I had to meet my copay towards the last month or so radiation. but I paid it.

Interviewer: Or if you gotta do what you gotta do.

Participant: Yeah.

Interviewer: Thank you. Thank you for sharing that. Now, I'm gonna ask you to think back prior to being diagnosed with cancer in particular. And I'm gonna ask you about like your experiences with heat, heat, and humidity.

Interviewer: So the 1st question I have for you is prior to your diagnosis. Did you ever experience physical illness as a result of exposure to heat and humidity?

Participant: Well, I can't really be in the sun too long. I start to get a little bit dizzy, especially if I exert myself because I sometimes tend to forget to drink water. So, I, in essence, just stay inside the house unless I have to go in the car and if I have to do yard work. I just have to hydrate a lot. and I'm just rather wearing the appropriate attire and hope I don't. You know, past out.

Interviewer: Interesting. Okay? And that's been a life thing that wasn't because of your top, your cancer diagnosis.

Participant: I don't believe it was. It was as I got older. Maybe as I got heavier because as a kid I used to want to be in the 100-degree temperature, and then and on the concrete of Bronx, and I was fine. But as I got older and started gaining weight, and I got to type 2 diabetes. So, I definitely can't stand heat.

Interviewer: Got it. Yet, here you are, living at a very, very hot, very, very humid. Tell me, outside of the dizziness have you ever felt like mentally impacted by heat, humidity, like move changes, or that kind of thing.

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Participant: What's wrong.

Interviewer: Prior to your diagnosis. Have you ever felt like mentally impacted by heat? You maybe it's super hot, super humid, abnormally. So do you ever experience like any type of move changes, or anything like that?

Participant: Well, I have gotten, you know, hot and cold flashes. I don't know if that has to do with the testosterone treatment. If that's with the radiation. Sometimes I feel that the room is too hot. My wife was saying that she feels fine. Mentally. Yeah, I'm stressed out from work. That's been ongoing. As a matter of fact, not as bad as it used to be when I was younger.

Interviewer: Got it. Got it

Interviewer: so, you mentioned that you would get, you know, by paying some time when you are going through the treatment for your cancer.

Interviewer: question, did any of your doctors ever talk to you about like interactions between your medication or treatment, and heat, or humidity.

Participant: The only thing that they was mentioning constantly is that I might feel fatigued and to let them know if I'm feeling fatigued, and I told them that I really can't tell the difference, because try to avoid any exertion outside already that if I did have fatigue it would just I wouldn't even notice it. I mean, I can do stuff inside the atmosphere, and I'm fine. But the moment I go outside within 5 min it's just the heat just sucks a life out of me.

Interviewer: Oh, my goodness, you definitely made a very interesting choice living in Miami.

Participant: Well, my.

Interviewer: Have you ever.

Participant: Down here, we and you know, while my parents are around, we can't leave Miami. So, when we were kids, we've been stuck in this terrible heat. so, I can't. I can't leave while my parents are here.

Interviewer: Have you ever, because of your sensitivity to heat like had to skip a scheduled doctor's appointment or clinic visit, just like, you know, in that spirit of I'm not going outside.

Participant: No, I will go outside. I just don't want to wait outside. So, I mean So far, I can have the A/C going. If it's a breezy day, I can lower the windows. Yeah, it's not

going to prevent me from going out. But I'm just let's say I'm not a fan of the beach. so, one convinces me to go to the beach. It might be once every 3 or 4 years.

Interviewer: let me ask is, have you ever had a conversation with your doctors or nurses about these heat sensitivities? About you know, heat, humidity, extreme temperatures, anything like that.

Participant: Honestly never came up. I guess it never appeared to me to mention it.

Interviewer: Got it. Okay? And they've never initiated a conversation either.

Participant: They've never brought it up, and you know, when you go to your routine visit to the doctor the moment you mention a problem the copay jumps.

Interviewer: Oh!

Participant: Yeah, if I go a routine visit, it's like \$50. The moment I mentioned I have a pain here, a pain there. Now it becomes a non-routine, and then all of a sudden you have. They charge more to the insurance, and then I have to pay the copay higher. So sometimes, unless it is really bothering me, I don't bring it up, which is unfortunate.

Interviewer: It is unfortunate it is unfortunate, but it's also very real. So I appreciate you, you sharing that and being honest about that.

Interviewer: So you know, you've mentioned like, instead of, you know, kind of bringing it up. You just avoid the heat. So I assume, like, if you are feeling super impacted by heat, seeking medical care, or like an emergency visit, would not be high on your your list.

Participant: Oh, no, I if I can avoid it, I will. Yeah, I when it, if you can say a moniker when it comes to heat, I retreat.

Interviewer: That's so cute. Wait.

Participant: Yeah, how? Many? Yeah.

Interviewer: I'm like, I'm like, 85% gonna use it.

Participant: It's not just the sun, because we have an umbrella in the back in our patio and I can sit underneath that umbrella out of direct sunlight, and that warm heat comes across. And just, I just can't wait to get back inside. It's just too much.

Interviewer: Okay, yeah, no. Definitely interested.

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Interviewer: So how much do you prioritize? I mean, it seems like you prioritize staying, staying at a comfortable temperature. Would you say that it's like, would you view it as a would you say that you view it as a necessity?

Participant: It's for me it's the priority to not be in the heat. I avoid theme parks if I can go to a lined for an event. I avoid it. If it's going to come, time for voting, I register for absentee ballot to avoid possibly being an hour outside.

Interviewer: okay, okay.

Participant: 9 in 10 immediately when I stay outside for a long time, because my skin is a lot lighter, because I don't go out, but when I do, I get sunburn.

Interviewer: Yes, understand?

Interviewer: so tell me about when you're at home. Are you able to run the A/C. As much as you like or like at the temperature that you want.

Participant: Well, we have a debate about that cause. She likes it colder and I don't like it too cold. So while I avoid the heat. I don't like extreme cold.

Interviewer: Okay.

Participant: As I feel, especially at night, I feel like I'm freezing, so we kind of go back and forth with the thermostat.

Interviewer: Got it. Got it?

Interviewer: Sounds like you all need the equivalent of that bid where you could like. Change the mattress firm this on each side, but like that for A/C.

Participant: Yeah.

Interviewer: Oh!

Participant: It's just putting on a thicker shirt or thicker pants and give up. And deal with the heat and stuffiness at all. If there's a hurricane and we lose power, I can at least struggle through it. She can't. She's worked for many and stay outside in the garden for hours in the heat. But she once she gets inside, she's like the stuffiness is from inside she can't cope with, but being outside and in the sun, you can be out there 2 h in the garden but 1 h with it closed windows, and no, no air conditioning, and she's going crazy.

Interviewer: Got it. Got it?

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Interviewer: So that is all I have to ask about, like your medical history and the heat impact. Next, I'm gonna ask about our social impact and and Bill, and like Bill stuff.

Interviewer: So social impact, you mentioned that, you know, when it comes to heat, you retreat like. There's an event you go outside. There's a line that you would just leave rather than wait in the heat.

Interviewer: Would you say that you have support from, like your friends and family to stay cool. Would you say that they understand your heat sensitivity?

Participant: They don't always understand.

Interviewer: Do they accommodate?

Participant: I guess if I insist.

Interviewer: Hmm, okay, okay.

Participant: Basically, if I'm getting amped up, and I'm getting really frustrated. And they'll okay. Fine.

Interviewer: Got it. But it's not a necessarily always super willing.

Participant: Yeah, it's never really offered.

Interviewer: Has there ever been a doctor recommended activity or event that you sit because of heat or humidity?

Participant: Well, the doctor keeps telling me to go for walks but for me it's just too hot.

Interviewer: Hmm! Have you considered, or tried to walk indoor, or is that positive.

Participant: To do what.

Interviewer: walk indoors. Like to, you know. Maybe get like a indoor treadmill or something.

Participant: We have a treadmill here. I don't really use it, because I tend to overheat while I'm using it.

Interviewer: Oh, okay.

Interviewer: got it. Got it, man. Okay.

Interviewer: Oh.

Interviewer: okay. So, you mentioned, you've talked actually a fair amount about like bills and co-pays and all that. Not so. Fun. Stuff!

Interviewer: How do you covered medical expenses including like medication and treatment doctor visits, but also like transportation and any other types of expenses?

Participant: Oh, no, I don't. I have my own transportation. I can get there. They don't really have given me any equipment. I've just paid the copays.

Interviewer: Okay. So, you're sharing it. They pay a lot of it but you pay what they don't.

Participant: Yeah, because Sometimes I'll go and apply something against the copay that you necessarily haven't paid, and I don't know how that happens because the 1st year, I didn't have to pay \$8,000 Copay and deductible. Then the next year, it was just bam, a surprise, so I don't know if the Insurance or the. I don't. I don't know how the billing went that it turned out that I was. I basically paid nothing, really, for the surgery. But, oh, man, the radiation.

Interviewer: Oh, wow!

Interviewer: Among like all of your other monthly expenses, would you say your medical bills were a large expense?

Participant: They, I would say that they're the largest expense per month would be medical because even a homeowners insurance rivals the cost of health insurance because of the changes.

Participant: So those are those are my top 2.

Participant: With medical could be 1st or second place, depending on the mood of the State Farm.

Interviewer: Yeah.

Interviewer: got it? Got it?

Interviewer: And if you think about your electricity bill, is that also a large expense? Or is that a relatively small expense in. You know the context of everything else you pay in a month.

Participant: You know the electricity is not that bad?

Interviewer: Okay.

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Interviewer: okay.

Interviewer: Oh.

Interviewer: are you aware of any programs? Or have you applied for any programs to help you manage medical expenses?

Participant: Not really.

Participant: I mean right now. The worst of my expenses are behind me, especially since I've gotten off the prawn. So, I wasn't aware that that I could have gotten some assistance.

Participant: My doctor tried to get assistance for the Ozempic to get me back on it. But for one, I really don't want to take it and for 2 he's still talking about that. I can pay as little as a hundred, 150 a month. I think that's too much. I kind of resist that. Yeah.

Interviewer: Hey?

Interviewer: Are you? You know, when you think about your medical expenses, and I'm glad that the worst of it is behind you but thinking so when you had those large bills coming in? Were you making any like tradeoffs or compromises to manage those expenses to stay up to date on those bills.

Interviewer: like, for example, not paying for certain medications, or resisting giving appointments, or like making tradeoffs in household expenses.

Participant: No, not really nothing, nothing important. If anything, it will be the luxuries we cut back on.

Interviewer: It would be the electricity you cut back on, or the luxury.

Participant: No, just we would just cut back on luxury. As far as electricity and water, none of that stuff have we sacrificed. If anything, we'll just say, well, we're not gonna eat out, you know, this week.

Interviewer: Okay.

Participant: Going to splurge on this. We're not gonna buy this.

Participant: So, I think we have a lot of non-essentials that we could put back on, but as far as the essentials that we haven't cut anything on that that I am aware of, we haven't even changed our insurance for something cheaper as far as the homeowner's coverage. Because we figure this is more important to have insurance and to say a couple of \$100 a year.

Interviewer: Yeah, I'm really glad that you all have the resources to maintain that.

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- Anxiety Regarding Extreme Weather During Hurricane Season
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Interviewer: Let me ask you if, you know, you had all the power in the world, what solutions would you like to see, you know, when it comes to like health and heat and humidity you mentioned? You have heat sensitivities. You're a cancer survivor. You're managing diabetes. So, like, as Miami gets hotter and hotter and more humid and more humid. What kind of solution do you think could help, you know, support you, or maybe your family or your neighborhood?

Participant: I mean stay hydrated. I guess. Watch the macronutrients. Not the go crazy on salt, I guess I guess I would say just staying hydrated and eating right is about the best thing you can do, and then everything else kind of shakes out.

Interviewer: Are there any like policies for, like programs, or like funding for like, maybe neighborhood changes that you think that might help also out, you know, in in addition to the lifestyle changes.

Participant: I mean, I don't know. I mean, not in my neighborhood. And I'm not really a super social person. So, if they had something community base that probably won't go.

Interviewer: Okay, I really appreciate your honesty.

Participant: Yeah, I kind of keep to myself.

Interviewer: Okay, okay.

Interviewer: Well, that's great. Thank you so much. I have a couple of more questions. But we're really toward the end. Would you like to add anything else related to your experience with heat and humidity?

Participant: well, I don't know. Everyone keeps talking about what exists, what doesn't exist, global warming climate change. I just wish that there was an answer. They gets so hot and the heat does scare me when I keep thinking about hurricane season. So that that adds to my hate of the heat, because when it gets super-hot and it's windy, but still hot, and it gets into May and June I start getting nervous, and said, it is just gonna rain, because, Imagine we're almost a hundred now, and we haven't really hit summer.

Participant: At that point, So I'm and I'm just kind of thinking what's gonna happen when I have to go from my car to the office and that he's beating down on me, I mean, it's only like 15 seconds, but I can't stand it.

Interviewer: Yeah, yeah, absolutely

Interviewer: definitely. Yeah, it's definitely something to consider. Like, I said, you just have. You have a sensitivity that you have to be. You have to consider it versus other folks respect. Miami's always had it, you know it is what it is.

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Interviewer: Is there anything that I didn't ask you today, you know, related to heat or health, or humidity, that you wish that I had asked.

Participant: No, I mean, you're talking about heat humidity, I mean, there's no conversation, I guess, on UV in the sun because I do know that does affect your eyes as far as cataracts.

Participant: getting it sooner.

Interviewer: That's.

Participant: Also another concern I have, because I've always had vision problems.

Participant: but

Participant: cataracts and the sun. I just hear that there's a direct relationship there.

Interviewer: So that's that's.

Participant: Something besides, people are worried about heat humidity. They should also worry about their vision. That's huge. Without that a lot of people can't cope.

Interviewer: Yeah, that's really interesting. We haven't to your point. We have definitely, not really thought about the and the development of other conditions that that folks would have to manage. Thank you for sharing that. Thank you for such a thoughtful answer.

Participant: Me, time.

Interviewer: So that is all the questions that I have for you at the moment

Participant: Alright. You guys.

Interviewer Assistant: Thank you!

Participant: Thank you.

Interviewer: Hi, bye, bye.